



AIR FORCE SENIOR NONCOMMISSIONED OFFICER ACADEMY STYLE GUIDE

TOOLS FOR EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

DAFH 33-337, The Tongue and Quill

August 2025

STYLE GUIDE

As an AFSNCOA student, you will prepare written and verbal assignments during the course of instruction. You must pay special attention in researching, developing and preparing your various communication assignments. The AFSNCOA Style Guide is used to aid and identify the standard requirements in writing and formatting your assignments.

DAFH 33-337, The Tongue and Quill, is the Air Force guide to prepare various military written and verbal correspondence. *The Tongue and Quill* is essential for proper staff work at all levels of leadership; it is also The Academy's baseline for formatting all written and verbal assignments. *The Tongue and Quill* aids with grammar, punctuation, mechanics and documentation. It is also important to note the guidance directs the use of the *Chicago Manual of Style*, 16th edition for citations. While we will utilize *The Tongue and Quill* as a foundation, the AFSNCOA Style Guide will add simplicity with a focus on learning and less on obscure formatting rules. Microsoft Word provides the ability to format documents with references as prescribed. If there are questions, please contact your instructor for clarification.

To demonstrate academic integrity, AFSNCOA students must behave in an honest and ethical way throughout their research and give credit to original authors through consistent use of citations. References and citations are required for both verbal and written communication assignments. Referencing gives credit and acknowledges the contribution to the original author. More importantly, references provide evidence, support and credibility to one's work, position or efforts to sway opinion in their favor. Citations occur in the text of your work in the form of direct quotations, a summary, or by paraphrasing concepts. Again, citing your sources adds credibility to your work.

All students are expected to uphold the highest standards of academic integrity and it is important to understand that **Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools are intended to support work, not replace original thought or effort**. Many AI platforms produce false references as sources and are not a valid source for academic work. As such, students should approach the use of AI tools with academic honesty and ethical considerations. While a student at the AFSNCOA, the misuse of AI tools, such as generating work with minimal personal input or using AI to deceive or misrepresent one's abilities will be treated as a violation of academic conduct, in other words, plagiarism. As such, students will disclose all AI tools used and the extent of their contribution in their work. This practice supports academic integrity, allowing the assessment of each student's individual work and highlights how AI was utilized to support the author's position. The following standards will apply to AFSNCOA assignments:

- a. Scholarly resources are required for all assignments, see assignment details in Canvas
- b. Students will refer to the AFSNCOA Style Guide (available in Canvas) for specifics in citing scholarly resources and citing AI material

- c. A combination of scholarly resources and AI use will not exceed 20% of any assignment (at least 80% of material will be the student's original thought)
- d. Cite all AI tools used, see page 3 below of the AFSNCOA Style Guide in Canvas
- e. If Grammarly is used, identify the use and save an original document for later reference if required
- f. Any AI detected and not cited will be considered plagiarism until the instructor conducts a review with the student and/or an academic review is conducted

All assignments will have at least 80% student original work and 20% or less will consist of scholarly sources and any AI content included in the assignment. All AI content presented in an assignment must be cited or the plagiarism rules apply and disciplinary release is possible based upon instructor review followed by a full academic review.

WRITTEN ASSIGNMENTS

Follow the prescribed citation format provided below:

Use the numbered endnote and bibliography system for documenting sources or references. All written text containing an outside source or reference supporting your position, put a superscript number at the end of a sentence and the numbering will be consecutive beginning with 1. This will correspond to the bibliography page (the last page of the assignment and does not count toward the overall page count). The numbering will continue in consecutive order for each outside source or reference used. Students must utilize the format as described and the sample provided below to avoid plagiarism issues and give credit where credit is due.

As an example, the **bibliography** should include the following items:

- (1) **Author's** or editor's full name (as it appears on the title page), last name first, including military rank (abbreviated) or academic title if included on the title page, or name of the institution responsible for writing the book (alternatively, the editor's name may follow the title of the book [see (3)]).
- (2) **Title** of the book, including subtitle, in italics.
- (3) **Editor**, compiler, or translator, if any.
- (4) **Edition**, if not the first.
- (5) **Number of volumes** (if referring to a multivolume work as a whole)
- (6) **Volume number of multivolume work** (if referring to one specific volume)
- (7) **Title of volume**, if applicable.
- (8) **Series**, if any, and number in the series.

(9) **Facts of publication**—city where published, publisher, and date of publication, all in parentheses.

(10) **Volume number** (if citing a multivolume work, all of whose volumes have the same title), followed by a colon

(11) **Page number(s)** of the specific citation; and

(12) **A URL** (or, preferably, a DOI, if available) for Internet sources or some indication of the medium cited (e.g., DVD, CD-ROM).

The Bibliography page and citations will look like the sample *below*:

If any AI tool is used it must be cited and included in the bibliography as seen in 5 & 6 below.

Bibliography (Sample)

1. Elder, Linda and Paul, Richard. *The Aspiring Thinker's Guide to Critical Thinking*. (Lanham MD, Rowman & Littlefield, 2019)
2. Kosal, Margaret E., ed. *Proliferation of Weapons- and Dual-Use Technologies: Diplomatic, Information, Military, and Economic Approaches*. (Springer Cham, 2021)
3. Gen. Brown, Charles Q. *Accelerate Change or Lose*. (Washington DC, Department of the Air Force, 2020)
4. AFSNCOA. *Critical Thinking Primer*. (Maxwell AFB-Gunter Annex AL, AFSNCOA, 2024)
5. Co-Pilot, response to “How a leader makes a pie from scratch?”, Microsoft, August 21, 2024, <https://copilot.microsoft.com/chat>.
6. ChatGPT, response to (the prompt used), OpenAI (owner), August 21, 2024 (date generated), <https://chat.openai.com/chat> (link if available).

Note: The Muir S. Fairchild Library also has online tools that make citation easy and simple in the prescribed Chicago Style.

If Grammarly is used to edit any assignments, ensure that you maintain a copy of the original paper. Immediately after the bibliography (double space) and enter:

“Grammarly used to edit the entire assignment or as appropriate (...to edit paragraph 2) on 21 Aug 24 (specific date)”

Background Paper

Refer to DAFH 33-337, The Tongue & Quill, page 226, for guidance on writing and formatting the Background Paper.

Preparing Written assignments

Write using the **State Elaborate Exemplify (SEE) Method**. As you prepare your written assignments, keep this format in mind as it is a tried-and-true example that works. In military writing, it is paramount to get to the point by stating the position, provide the evidence then explain the connection and provide the why. These details transform vague information into actionable items. In military communication evidence is not optional, it is ammunition for decision-makers. Gen Dunford, former CJCS directed a special interest item be implemented into PME, “...ensure all staff can prepare

concise written recommendations.”

- 1) **State** the main idea in a single sentence, clear and concise,
- 2) **Elaborate** this statement to expand by adding depth and breadth to support the main idea/**Evidence** is the empirical data that supports
- 3) **Exemplify** to provide a good example of a topic or concept/**Explain** the importance of your examples (how the evidence connects with your overall claim or proves your position)

Examples:

1. **State (Topic Sentence):**

- Begin your paragraph with a clear and concise **topic sentence** that introduces the main idea. This sentence sets the tone and direction for the entire paragraph.
- For instance: “The impact of wearing a uniform that is comfortable and is appealing impacts team performance.”

2. **Elaborate/Evidence (Provide Details):**

- Elaborate on the topic by offering relevant details or evidence. Use scientific research, expert opinions, or data to support your point. Cite your sources.
- Example: “Studies at Oxford University reveal increased performance when uniforms are comfortable, do not bind or prevent body motion in all weather conditions.”

3. **Exemplify/Explain (Give Examples):**

- Illustrate your point with concrete examples. These can be real-life scenarios or case studies.
- Example: “In professional and collegiate athletics, teams have partnered with numerous vendors to develop comfortable and appealing uniforms, creating a multitude of improvements in performance but it has also opened up a multi-billion-dollar boom for the garment industry.”

*The SEE Method is **not** a bullet statement or a group of sentences that follow as seen above.

By combining these elements, you will **create paragraphs that inform, persuade, and engage readers** effectively. Remember to cite scholarly credible sources when providing evidence! There is certainly no reason to use an AI Tool here.

An average sample of the SEE Method can be found in Canvas.

THE SAMPLE BELOW IS NOT THE SEE METHOD AND IS UNACCEPTABLE.

State: A leader is someone who through trust, care, and respect has made themselves a key component in the organization and made an impact on you directly. My leadership philosophy is to “be the leader you needed when you were young.”

Elaborate: By adhering to the standards and exemplifying those traits, I can build myself, and earn the trust and respect of my team to create an environment that encourages technical expertise and innovation. All members are empowered to contribute their best through adaptive feedback, open communication, continuous learning, and mutual respect.

Exemplify/Explain: Growth can come naturally, taught, or mimicked. If you have ever heard the statement “fake it till you make it” that, is based on mimicking those you hold in high standards. These members inspire followership. I actively seek opportunities to recognize and celebrate individual and team achievements, reinforcing our squadron’s commitment to growth.

VERBAL PRESENTATIONS

During verbal presentations, citing and qualifying references are equally important. Citing and qualifying gives the speaker more credibility, increasing their chances of success. When citing, you are giving credit to an obvious source. Occasionally, you may want to refer to a quote or piece of information from a less-known person. When this happens, you should qualify the person by providing their title and/or credentials.

Citing example:

...According to Dr. Billy Bob, in his book *Internet of Things and AI*, “Co-Pilot and Chat-Gpt are useful but one must be extremely cautious of their use in academics.”....

...In December 2021 a Rand study on *Adaptive Engagement for Undergoverned Spaces*, stated, “Strategic planning should emphasize adaptiveness; it should conceive issues in system frameworks (multiple countries, time spans, dimensions of competition, domains of action)”...

Qualifying example:

...Dr. Scott, a Noted Astrophysicist from the Hogwart’s School of Space stated, “To infinity and beyond is not just a moniker, it is near reality with Space X, NASA and Space Force’s scheduled launch of the new space vehicle.”

...John Euddy, Department Head, Center for Disease Control and Prevention, stated “proper planning for medical evaluation is vital in determining how effective programs are and how effective medical programs can become.”....

You are not required in a presentation to identify specific page(s), a publisher, date published or anything beyond qualifying the person or identifying the book, article or study in verbal presentations.